

Swimming for Arthritis: A Complete Guide

Why swimming is one of the best exercises for arthritis. Learn how water-based activities reduce pain and improve mobility.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Swimming and aquatic exercise are among the most effective forms of physical activity for people with arthritis. The buoyancy of water supports up to 90% of your body weight, making movement easier and less painful.

Why Water Works

- **Buoyancy** reduces joint loading by up to 90%
- **Warm water** (28–32°C) relaxes muscles and increases blood flow
- **Hydrostatic pressure** reduces swelling in joints
- **Resistance** builds muscle strength without weights

What the Research Says



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A 2023 Cochrane review of aquatic exercise for OA found: - Significant reductions in pain (moderate evidence) - Improved physical function (moderate evidence) - Enhanced quality of

life (low-moderate evidence) - Benefits comparable to land-based exercise

Best Swimming Strokes for Arthritis

| Stroke | Best For | Avoid If | |-----|-----|-----| | Backstroke | Shoulder, hip, knee OA | Neck problems | | Breaststroke | General fitness | Knee OA (modified kick) | | Front crawl | Upper body strength | Shoulder impingement | | Aqua walking | All types, beginners | — |

Getting Started



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1. ****Find a warm pool**** — hydrotherapy pools (33–36°C) are ideal but standard heated pools (28–30°C) work too
2. ****Start with 15–20 minutes**** and build to 30–45 minutes
3. ****Aim for 2–3 sessions per week****
4. ****Try aqua aerobics**** — structured classes with instructor guidance
5. ****Use a float**** if needed for support

UK Pool Resources

- ****Swim England**** — find pools near you with disability-friendly facilities
- ****NHS hydrotherapy**** — ask your GP or physiotherapist for a referral
- ****Versus Arthritis**** — local groups often organise warm water sessions
- ****Everyone Active / Better Leisure**** — concession rates for people with disabilities

Tips for Comfort

- Shower in warm water before entering the pool
- Use neoprene gloves if hands are affected
- Avoid cold pools (below 26°C)
- Stretch gently after your session
- Apply moisturiser — chlorine can dry skin

Written by Mark Thompson, Aquatic Physiotherapist, NHS

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about swimming for arthritis: a complete guide?

Short answer: Swimming is beneficial for arthritis as water's buoyancy supports up to 90% of body weight, reducing joint load and pain. Warm water, ideally 28–32°C, relaxes muscles and increases blood flow, while hydrostatic pressure can reduce joint swelling. Regular sessions, starting with 15–20 minutes and building to 30–45 minutes, two to three times weekly, can improve physical function and quality of life.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk